

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Storm surge

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

If a storm-surge evacuation order covers you, leave for a safe location outside the surge zone before roads close. Wind strength alone does not describe surge danger. Never walk or drive through coastal floodwater.

Do now.

- ☐ **Check the surge zone**
01 Use your local emergency management evacuation map and official order.
- ☐ **Leave early**
02 Choose an inland destination outside the evacuation area and use designated routes.
- ☐ **Avoid shoreline viewing**
03 Stay away from beaches, seawalls and flooded coastal roads.
- ☐ **If trapped**
04 Contact emergency services with your location and move to a safer higher level without entering a closed attic.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If you live in a surge zone, arrange an inland destination before the storm. Do not wait for public transport that has not been confirmed. Once roads are flooded, do not force a crossing; use the safest elevated location and signal if trapped.

Watch for.

Storm surge may arrive before the worst wind. Do not wait for visible water.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check the surge zone. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Storm surge may arrive before the worst wind. Do not wait for visible water.

Keep essentials within reach.

For storm surge, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If you live in a surge zone, arrange an inland destination before the storm. Do not wait for public transport that has not been confirmed. Once roads are flooded, do not force a crossing; use the safest elevated location and signal if trapped. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Return only after reentry is allowed; damaged bridges, debris and polluted water can remain.

First decision: Check the surge zone

Use your local emergency management evacuation map and official order. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If you live in a surge zone, arrange an inland destination before the storm. Do not wait for public transport that has not been confirmed. Once roads are flooded, do not force a crossing; use the safest elevated location and signal if trapped. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Storm surge may arrive before the worst wind. Do not wait for visible water. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

If a storm-surge evacuation order covers you, leave for a safe location outside the surge zone before roads close. Wind strength alone does not describe surge danger. Never walk or drive through coastal floodwater. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For storm surge, keep the specific hazard in view: Storm surge may arrive before the worst wind. Do not wait for visible water.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: If trapped. Contact emergency services with your location and move to a safer higher level without entering a closed attic. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

NWS · Hurricane safety

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/hurricane>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/storm-surge/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.